

Convinced the room can see exactly how shaky and nervous you feel

7 findings · 12-step checklist · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

Your hands are shaking mid-sentence and you're sure the whole room has clocked it. Believing the worst already happened can feel safer than hoping it didn't and being wrong, but the room isn't seeing what you think.

THE GOAL

Keep moving through what you planned to say. Your job is getting through the material, not managing how composed you look.

CHECKLIST

The instant your hands or voice start to shake mid-sentence and you're sure the room has clocked it.

- ☐ Finish the word or sentence you're mid-way through before you do anything else.
- ☐ Let your hands **stay exactly where they are**, on your notes or the lectern, instead of clenching them still.
- ☐ Keep your feet planted and your shoulders where they are instead of shifting your stance to hide the shake.
- ☐ If you lose your place on the page, find the next full sentence and start there.
- ☐ Skip any comment about being nervous and go straight into your next line.
- ☐ If a word doesn't come out cleanly, move on to the next one instead of repeating it.
- ☐ Look down at your next point on the page or slide instead of scanning the room for a reaction.
- ☐ Say your next planned sentence at the pace you rehearsed, not faster.
- ☐ If you catch yourself thinking about how you look, **bring your attention back** to the sentence you're saying.
- ☐ Carry on to the next point on your outline instead of pausing to judge how the last part went.
- ☐ Move to your next point without waiting for the shake to stop first.
- ☐ Finish the section you're on and move into the next one as planned.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Worrying that the room can see you shake doesn't just sit alongside the fear. **It can feed it.**
- 2 How hard your heart is pounding isn't a reliable measure of how nervous you actually are.
- 3 The shake you're fighting is **closer to its peak than its start**. For people who run more anxious, physical stress tends to spike in that first minute and ease from there as the talk goes on.

Why this feels bigger than it is

WATCH

Worrying that the room can see you shake doesn't just sit alongside the fear. **It can feed it.**

Anchoring on how anxious you feel inside is what inflates the sense that it shows, feeding the fear it started from. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

The room is not reading you the way you're reading yourself.

Audiences rate speakers as calmer than the speakers rate themselves: they're just not very accurate at reading private anxiety. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

How hard your heart is pounding isn't a reliable measure of how nervous you actually are.

Heart rate and skin response didn't line up with **how nervous people said they felt**, even measured in the same speech. [Source 2](#)

What fighting it costs you

DON'T

Fighting to keep your hands or face perfectly still costs you something.

People told to hide what they felt had a harder time remembering details they'd just been told. [Source 3](#)

DON'T

Naming your nerves out loud doesn't make the room more forgiving of them. It's more likely to point the room at something they hadn't noticed yet.

Once you've said it, there's something specific to listen for that wasn't there a second earlier. [Source 4](#)

What the room is actually judging

KNOW

The parts of the talk you think are falling apart, the room usually doesn't see that way. Speakers routinely score their own delivery below what trained observers give the same performance.

This showed up as a trend across the group of presenters, not from just an unusual few standing out. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

The shake you're fighting is **closer to its peak than its start**. For people who run more anxious, physical stress tends to spike in that first minute and ease from there as the talk goes on.

The most anxious speakers in this research calmed the most once they were a little way into the talk. [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. <https://crisp.org.uiowa.edu/sites/crisp.org.uiowa.edu/files/2020-04/15.4.pdf>
2. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9158251/>
3. <https://psu.pb.unizin.org/psych425/chapter/response-modulation-expressive-suppression/>
4. <https://milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/stand-up-speak-out-3/chapter/chapter-3-speaking-confidently/>
5. <https://acuresearchbank.acu.edu.au/bitstreams/870781de-711d-4b66-bdef-64d48bd33a1f/download>
6. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10417940500503555>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Nerves before and during a talk at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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